I returned to the ship and must have set a world record for holding my breath, for the Cortland was due to leave for Bikini three days later, on May 17.

The next day I went to see Colonel Jordan again, and it was official. I was taken off Operation Crossroads and was not to go to Bikini. I was, instead, to be sent back to Camp Lee.

I was delighted.

On the morning of May 16 (Gertrude's birthday), I was off the Cortland after a fifteen-day stay aboard, and I was officially off Operation Crossroads, too, after seventy-five days on it. I had accomplished it with just one day to spare. 7

On May 17, the Cortland sailed, as did the other ships. The other six specialists were off to sea on the way to Bikini, and I remained behind on Oahu. In a way, I had betrayed them, but it was through no voluntary act of my own; it was the Army's act of stopping Gertrude's allotment that had brought it about. In my place, each one of them would have done what I did.

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On the nineteenth, my orders came through, and I was sent back to the United States "by the first available water transportation." That meant six days at sea, but that was good enough. An airplane would have been much faster, but I decided I didn't want an airplane.

It was not until May 27, after I had been off the Cortland for seven days (and by now the specialists must be at Bikini), that I was finally moved. To my surprise, I was taken to an airport and told to get on a plane.

I tried to protest, pointing to my orders, but a sergeant said, "Private, don't give me a hard time. Get on that plane!" So I did. It's a lot harder to argue with sergeants than with colonels.

A little after midnight the plane took off, and Honolulu disappeared in the distance. I had been in Oahu for seventy-four days—2V2 months.

It was not much of a plane. It was a large propeller-driven transport with its insides eviscerated so that it could carry as many men as possible. I tried to sleep stretched out on the floor, but that didn't work very well. When dawn came, we found ourselves flying over clouds equipped with little blue triangles here and there. It finally dawned on me that these were spaces